

"The Servant"

Q1. Why had Gerasim been going about in vain in the village?

Ans: Gerasim had been working for a merchant in Moscow. But then he was summoned back to his village for military duty. However, he had not been drafted. So, he had nothing to do in the village. It seemed dull to him in the village. He was not used to village life. He didn't like to work in the village. That was why he had been going about in vain in the village.

Q2. Where had he been working? Why did he return to his village?

Ans: Gerasim had been working in Moscow. He was from a village, but he had been living in Moscow since early boyhood. When still a mere child, he had gone to work in a brewery as bottle-washer, and later as a lower servant in a house. In the last two years, he had been a merchant's employee. But then he was summoned back to his village for military duty. So he had to give up his job and return to his village.

Q3. What did the coachman tell Gerasim when he narrated his story?

Ans. The coachman gave Gerasim a long lecture on honesty and faithfulness. He said that the workers do not serve their employers diligently. The employers in return lose their trust in them. When they leave their jobs, they usually muddle up their way back to them. Soon the coachman added that they (the workers) should serve their masters in a way that their masters should think a lot of them and take them willingly again when they come back to them. The coachman gives his own example. He says that if ever he leaves his place and goes home, his master would gladly take him back. Thus, he tells Gerasim indirectly that if he had served his master sincerely, he would not have to hanker for a job.

Q4. How did the coachman persuade his master to employ Gerasim?

Ans: The coachman had a glib tongue. He first tried to convince his master that it was no longer worth to keep Polikarpych as a servant. He had become too old to do his job well. The coachman said Polikarpych never shoveled the snow away on time. Thus, he could bring his master trouble from the police. And when it was his turn to be a night watchman, he slipped away at least ten times a night. Thus, the coachman painted Polikarpych in very dark colours. The master had real sympathy for his old servant who had sincerely served him for fifteen years. He thought it a sin to leave him to starve in his old age. But the coachman was perfect in his glib art. He succeeded at last in persuading his master to dismiss Polikarpych and instead employ Gerasim who, he said, was a young man from his village with no job.

Q5. Why was the master reluctant to disengage the old servant?

Ans. The master was a very noble man He had all love and sympathy for his old servant. The servant had served him for fifteen years. He had never any complaint against him. He had the concern that where would he go in his old age if he was sacked from the service. He knew that he had a wife to feed. He thought it to be sin to leave the old man and woman to starve in their old age. He was conscience- stricken. His conscience didn't allow him to dismiss him from service. Above all there wasn't any cause whatsoever to dismiss him.

06. What did Gerasim hear while crossing the yard?

Ans: Gerasim heard voices coming from a room. They were the voices of a man and a woman. They were the old servant and his wife who were being disengaged from there. They were wailing over the way they had been dismissed. They had served their master honestly and faithfully. But now in their old age they had been asked to go. They had nowhere to go to. They could do nothing but beg. Gerasim heard the man saying that the coachman was the real devil on whose insistence it had happened. At this, the wife called him a serpent, she said that she would go to the master and tell him how the coachman had been stealing his things. The old woman burst out sobbing. She said that the coachman had ruined them.

Q.7. What did the old couple think about the master?

Ans: The old couple was very angry with the master. They thought that their master was very mean. They had served him honestly and faithfully for fifteen years. But now he had dismissed them in their old age. The old woman said that their master was selfish who cared only for his own advantage. He had no sympathy for them. But the husband said that the master was not so much to blame. He called the coachman the real culprit. But finally, it was the master who had to take the decision of dismissal of the old man. Thus, they were not happy with their master at all. They felt that he was equally wicked.

Q8. What was the effect of old couples conversation on Gerasim?

Ans : Gerasim had heard all that the old couple had said. Their conversation stabbed him like a dagger. He realized what misfortune he would be bringing to the old couple, and it made him sick at heart. He stood there for a long while, saddened, lost in thought. He felt sorry for the old couple. He was remorse stricken. He was in a fix. Finally, he turned and went back to Yegor, the coachman. He thanked him for all the trouble he had taken for him. But said that he didn't like the place. He would look for another one for himself.

Q.9. How does the story reflect the humility of Gerasim?

Ans : Gerasim is full of modesty and it is reflected all through the story. In the very beginning, Gerasim is looking for a job in Moscow. But he fails to find one. While finding the

job there, he stays with some of his friends and relatives. When he finds that some of his friends suffer unpleasantness from their masters on his account, he decides not to be a burden on them. Because of this, sometimes he goes a whole day without eating. But he never says a word against any one. He comes to a man from his village who is a coachman with a rich merchant. The merchant starts giving him a lecture on faithfulness and honesty. He indirectly blames Gerasim because his previous master had refused to take him back. Gerasim listens to all this with downcast eyes. This shows his humility. The humility is at its climax at the end of the story. He hears the old couple wailing over the dismissal of the old servant from his service. He feels very sorry for the old couple. He comes back to the coachman and refuses to take the place which he needs badly. Truly Gerasim is a very humble character.

Writing work

Q1. Compare and contrast the characters of the Gerasim and the coachman?

Ans: Gerasim and the coachman have nothing common except that they are from the same village. The two are poles apart in their character. One is the opposite of the other. Gerasim is humble, simple-hearted, kind and loving, self-sacrificing and less talkative. On the other hand, the coachman is proud, cunning, hard-hearted, selfish and abusive. No doubt the coachman helps Gerasim to get a job with his master but the entire episode shows more of his cunningness than helpfulness. And the contrast becomes so clear at the end of the story when Gerasim overhears the old couple's conversation and refuses to take their place. The coachman becomes furious and calls him an idiot. In nutshell, we see a devil in one and an angel in the other.

Q2. Theme of the story (The Servant)

Ans: The theme of the story, 'The Servant' is sincerity and humility. This theme runs across the whole story. Humility and sincerity are the real wealth of a person, the material wealth though needed by a person is not everything. One cannot achieve all happiness from wealth. Sincerity gives a long lasting pleasure. It makes us light hearted. Sincerity in a person makes him a human being. If we lack sincerity, we are worse than a beast. We see in the story at the end that Gerasim feels light hearted even though he loses the position which he badly needs.